GRIDLOCK OF ARRESTS

- On August 5, 2019, Centre revokes special status/ autonomy of J&K granted under Article 370 of the Constitution
- Around 8,000 people were detained, including politicians, separatists and activists, amidst a blanket communication blackout and military build-up. Many are still behind bars
- Ex-CMs Farooq and Omar Abdullah, Mehbooba Mufti, veteran Hurriyat leader, the late Syed Ali Geelani and Mirwaiz Umar Farooq put under house arrest
- NIA also launched probes into alleged links to terror funding against Geelani, his family, the Mirwaiz, and several others
- Geelani, Kashmir's most hawkish separatist leader, passed away on Sept 1, 2021
- Mirwaiz's release on Sept 22, coming after release of clerics Abdul Rashid Dawoodi and Mushtaq Ahmad Veeri, marks a softening of policy

even the state BJP seeking their release.

A huge throng of cheering, slogan-chanting devotees greeted the 50-year-old Mirwaiz as he arrived at Jama Masjid to lead the Friday prayers. Wearing white-and-gold robes, he broke down as he climbed the stairs of the pulpit and talked about peace and reconciliation, calling for the return of Kashmiri Pandits. "We have been called separatist, anti-national and peace disruptors. We represent the interests and aspirations of Kashmiris. We seek a peaceful resolution of their issues," he said, carefully avoiding any acrimony towards the Centre. Instead, he used Prime Minister Narendra Modi's words on Ukraine—that "this is not an era of war"—in the context of Kashmir. He added, "We have believed...in efforts seeking resolution through an alternative to violent means, which is dialogue and reconciliation. We have personally suffered for pursuing this route."

His soberly worded, almost conciliatory speech is being seen as a departure from the past. Separatists, both moderates like the Mirwaiz and hardliners like the late Syed Ali Geelani, would often touch upon United Nations resolutions on Kashmir and alleged human rights violations in their speeches—and these would routinely be followed by bouts of stone-throwing. After his September 22 speech, as the Mirwaiz left the complex, there were no raucous protests outside Jama Masjid.

It was a positive sign that indicated his readiness to move on, feels Rekha Choudhary, former political science professor at Jammu University. "Interestingly, one can compare his political evolution to that of Omar Abdullah. In the past few years, Omar has become seasoned and pragmatic without losing his political space," she says. "From the speech, one can see a similar pragmatism in Mirwaiz too. No overt bitterness or resentment towards the Centre. Just a sense of appreciation of the times."

In the past, Mirwaiz has drawn criticism from the hawks for a softer approach towards the Centre. Being a 'moderate' within the separatist space has never been easy. Hurriyat leader Abdul Gani Lone was only the more prominent among those assassinated by militants for favouring talks with New Delhi. In fact, it was an assassination at the hands of militants—that of his own father, Mirwaiz Maulvi Farooq, in 1990—that had yanked the Mirwaiz into public life at an early age. Yet, unfazed by that overall context of threats, and without much diluting the core stand of Kashmiri self-determination, he had exhibited the latitude to engage with the Centre—at a time when then PM A.B. Vajpayee too was meeting the separatists half-way. It was a defining juncture of his political career and many in New Delhi identified him as "potential mainstream". Says Choudhary, "As a political actor in Kashmir, he is relatively less controversial."

ALTAF BUKHARI HAD DEMANDED MIRWAIZ'S RELEASE DURING HIS MEETING WITH AMIT SHAH

With the Lok Sabha election drawing closer, many say the BJP may use the Mirwaiz's softened stance to their advantage—showcasing it as a vindication of their policies. In June, Jammu and Kashmir Apni Party president Altaf Bukhari had met Union home minister Amit Shah in New Delhi, and urged him to go for confidence-building measures in J&K. Among his suggestions was the trio's release. Bukhari, who has been accused of being 'BJP's B-team', later engaged with former Hurriyat chairman Abdul Gani Bhat, another moderate, and Shia leader Aga Syed Hassan Mosavi Al Safavi, igniting some curiosity. Syed Muzaffar Rizvi of the Itihadul Muslimeen, a Hurriyat constituent, even joined Apni Party and was appointed its Kashmir vice-president on September 11. "The doors of our party are open for anyone... who believes in the Indian Constitution, doesn't believe in communal politics and is not involved in drug abuse and terrorism," says Bukhari.

A senior policy analyst says the Mirwaiz's presence will reduce the political space for traditional parties like the National Conference and the Peoples Democratic Party. In the vacuum created by mass arrests after the annulment of Article 370, the two were trying to cater to both the mainstream and separatist constituencies—projecting themselves as the 'sole voice' of Kashmir. That will change now. "Mirwaiz's release will also debunk the propaganda that religious freedom has been curbed in J&K," says the analyst. "It is just the beginning, an experimental move. More CBMs can follow." All considered, a turn so unexpected it must count as a googly. ■